

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Carpentry & Remodeling English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Carpenters, remodelers, finish carpenters, joinery installers, and carpentry crew leads.

Original fictional language practice, not carpentry instruction, structural assessment, legal advice, or a statement of code or permit requirements. All dimensions, incidents, quotations, products, and schedules in exercises are invented. Structural decisions, hazardous materials, tool use, installation methods, and site safety require qualified people and project-specific procedures. Sources establish occupational context, not endorsement of these cases.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

acceptance sample

An agreed physical reference against which specified aspects of finished work are compared.

access window

An agreed period when a crew may enter and use a particular work area.

allowance

An amount included in a project budget for a specified item whose final selection or cost is not yet settled.

as-built record

A record intended to describe the work as actually completed, including documented changes.

blocking

Short framing pieces between other members, used for specified support or restraint.

care sheet

Product-specific information about looking after a finished material or item.

change order

A project document recording an agreed alteration to the contracted work and its stated effects.

concealed condition

An existing site condition that was not visible during the initial assessment.

datum

An agreed reference point or line from which project dimensions are measured.

elevation

A drawing showing a vertical face of a room, wall, or assembly.

exclusion

Work or supply specifically left out of an agreed scope.

finish sample

A physical example used to compare a proposed surface color, sheen, or texture.

finished opening

The opening measured between specified completed surrounding surfaces; this is not automatically the usable clear passage with a door installed and open.

flush

Aligned in the same plane as an adjoining surface, without an intended step.

grain

The direction and visible pattern of fibers in wood.

jamb

A side or top member of a door or window frame.

joist

A horizontal structural member that supports a floor or ceiling.

lookahead schedule

A short-term plan showing upcoming site activities and their dependencies.

making good

Repairing or restoring finishes disturbed by building work to the agreed extent and standard; called making good in some regions.

plumb

Vertical relative to gravity; distinct from level, which describes a horizontal reference.

profile

The cross-sectional shape of a molding or trim piece.

protection plan

The agreed arrangements for protecting retained surfaces and occupants during specified work.

return visit

A planned later attendance to review or complete identified outstanding work.

reveal

An intentionally visible strip, gap, or setback between adjoining finished components.

rough opening

The framed space intended to receive a door or window unit before surrounding finishes are complete.

scribe allowance

Extra material specified so a component can be fitted to an adjoining irregular surface.

section detail

A drawing showing a cut-through view of an assembly and its relationships.

snag list

A list of observed unfinished or unsatisfactory items requiring agreed follow-up; commonly called a punch list in U.S. usage.

subfloor

The supporting floor layer beneath the finished floor covering.

trade interface

A point where one trade's work meets or depends on another trade's work.

veneer

A thin layer of wood bonded to a supporting material to provide a wood surface.

warranty document

A document stating the provider's warranty terms and conditions for identified work or products.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask what the dimension describes

Is ___ measured between ___ or ___?

When you say clear width, do you mean ___?

We have the dimension, but still need ___.

An opening dimension needs units and reference surfaces. Rough opening, finished opening, door-leaf width, and usable clear passage are different quantities. Even a finished opening measurement may not establish passage with the door and hardware present. Ask which requirement matters before discussing an order size.

Word combinations in this lesson

verify the opening: confirm which opening and measurement basis are meant

measure between finished faces: state the surfaces that bound a dimension

allow for the jamb: include the frame in the dimensional discussion

establish a datum: agree the reference used for dimensions

Compare the properties that matter

Both samples ___, whereas only ___.

The difference in appearance is ___.

The quoted lead time is ___; the site date remains ___.

A profile is shape; grain and sheen describe different aspects of appearance. Use the same criteria for both samples. A quoted lead time is supplier information, not a promise about the entire remodeling schedule.

Word combinations in this lesson

match the existing profile: compare trim shapes, not just overall width

approve a finish sample: accept a particular reference for appearance

follow the grain: describe the visible direction of wood fibers

compare like for like: use the same dimensions and finish conditions

Make a drawing question answerable

On ___ revision ___, the dimension is ___ .

Could you reconcile ___ with ___?

This affects ___; please confirm ___.

A useful query lets the designer find the conflict without guessing. Name both documents and their revisions, describe the same physical location, and ask for the intended relationship. A review deadline is not permission to choose a dimension.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the latest revision: confirm the current drawing issue

raise a drawing query: ask for clarification of a specific conflict

maintain an even reveal: describe a consistent visible spacing

reconcile the detail: obtain one consistent interpretation of conflicting information

Describe a finding and its limits

I can see ___ at ___ .

That does not establish whether ___ .

The assessment needs to address ___ before ___.

Location, visibility, and source matter. A stain is an observation; decay and structural adequacy are conclusions requiring appropriate assessment. Keep urgent site concerns within the project's safety arrangements rather than treating this exercise as an inspection procedure.

Word combinations in this lesson

report visible staining: describe appearance without naming a cause

identify the affected area: locate the observation precisely

separate evidence from inference: distinguish what is seen from what is assumed

request a condition assessment: ask the appropriate specialist to evaluate the finding

Offer a bounded choice

The current scope includes ___ and excludes ___ .

We can retain ___ or request a price for ___ .

If you choose ___, we still need to agree ___.

Name the agreed work, the requested addition, and the unanswered cost or timing questions. An allowance is not automatic approval. A request for a quotation does not authorize construction. Skirting is commonly called baseboard in U.S. usage; making good means repairing or restoring disturbed finishes.

Word combinations in this lesson

price an addition: obtain a cost for work beyond the current scope

clarify an exclusion: identify what a proposal leaves out

agree the extent of making good: define the surrounding restoration work

review the schedule impact: assess how a change affects timing

Update the dependency, not just the date

Delivery is confirmed for ___; access remains ___ .

The next activity depends on ___ .

That window covers ___, not ___.

Several schedules can be true at once and still conflict. State the material status, room access status, and resulting dependency separately. Do not use a clear corridor as an assumed storage or work area.

Word combinations in this lesson

sequence the trades: agree the order of different crews' activities

confirm room access: establish which area is available and when

protect retained finishes: preserve surfaces that are not being replaced

flag a dependency: identify an activity that relies on another being complete

Correct the claim and specify the item

My earlier statement about ___ was too broad.

At ___, the edge is ___ relative to ___.

The recorded observation is ___; the remedy remains ___.

Use location and relationship rather than a vague judgment such as bad. Acknowledge an inaccurate statement directly. Recording a snag does not by itself identify its cause, the remedy, or the contractual outcome. Snag list and punch list name the same type of follow-up list here.

Word combinations in this lesson

check against the sample: compare the specified feature with the agreed reference

identify a proud edge: describe an edge projecting beyond its neighbor

agree a snag description: settle the exact location and observed issue

confirm the review outcome: distinguish accepted work from items still open

Hand over what is complete and what remains open

This document covers ___, not ___.

___ has accepted follow-up for ___.

The update is due ___; the visit date is ___.

A handover is more useful when each document matches the supplied product and each outstanding item has an owner. A promised update date is not necessarily a delivery or return-visit date. Do not paraphrase warranty terms as guaranteed coverage.

Word combinations in this lesson

hand over the care sheet: provide the correct product-care information

match the product reference: link a document to the item actually supplied

schedule a return visit: agree a later attendance for defined work

close an outstanding item: record completion after the relevant review

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Confirming openings and measurement references

The hall drawing labels a door opening 900 millimeters. The client assumes this is clear passage width. The note does not say rough or finished opening; no door has been ordered. The designer can clarify the reference.

The drawing gives 900 millimeters, but it does not identify the measurement surfaces. Do you need that as the clear passage width, or were you referring to the framed opening? I will ask the designer to confirm the datum and jamb allowance before we treat this dimension as an order size.

Try it again: The designer confirms a rough opening, but the client still asks whether a large cabinet will fit. Separate the two measurements.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Selecting timber, trim, and visible finishes

For a fictional study remodel, sample A is solid oak trim with pronounced grain and a ten-day quoted lead time. Sample B is oak-veneered trim with a more uniform appearance and a four-day quoted lead time. Both match the requested profile. No sample is selected.

Both samples match the requested profile. Sample A has more pronounced grain and a quoted ten-day lead time, whereas sample B looks more uniform and is quoted at four days. Those are appearance and supply differences, not a general quality ranking. Which appearance would you like us to use as the reference?

Try it again: The supplier revises A's lead time to twelve days. Recompare the options without changing the client's appearance preference.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Reading details and resolving drawing conflicts

Cabinet elevation C4 revision B shows a 20-millimeter reveal. Section S2 revision B shows 15 millimeters at the same end panel. Fabrication release is due for review at 14:00. The designer has not clarified which dimension applies.

Could you clarify the end-panel reveal before our 14:00 fabrication review? Elevation C4 revision B shows 20 millimeters, while section S2 revision B shows 15 at the same location. Please identify the intended dimension and the drawing that needs correction. We will keep this panel out of fabrication release until the conflict is resolved.

Try it again: You can answer only at 15:00. Agree how the panel's release status will be described at the 14:00 review.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Discussing concealed conditions without guessing

An existing exposed subfloor has dark staining beside the laundry doorway. The client asks whether the joists are rotten. The carpenter has not assessed structural condition and the joists are not visible. The project lead can arrange a qualified assessment.

The dark staining is visible on the subfloor beside the laundry doorway. It does not tell me the condition of the joists underneath, which are not visible. I cannot confirm decay or its cause from this observation. I will ask the project lead to arrange an assessment before we discuss any resulting scope change.

Try it again: The client remembers an old spill. Attribute that recollection without treating it as the confirmed explanation.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Separating requested extras from agreed work

The agreed bedroom scope includes replacing skirting only. The client requests a built-in bench; decorating is excluded. The carpenter can arrange a separate quotation, but no bench dimensions, price, or completion date are agreed.

The current bedroom scope covers skirting replacement and excludes decorating. A built-in bench would be an addition. We can keep the present scope or obtain a separate quotation for the bench, including any making good. If you want that comparison, we first need your intended size; its price and timing remain open.

Try it again: The client adds matching wall paneling. Identify it as another item to assess, not an assumed part of the bench.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Coordinating access and other trades

The joinery delivery is confirmed for Tuesday morning. The decorator has not released the study for carpentry access. The hallway is available for a separate trim review at 11:00, but not for material storage. The site coordinator needs the current status.

Tuesday morning's joinery delivery is confirmed, but study access is still awaiting the decorator's release. The hallway is available for the 11:00 trim review only, not storage. Please confirm the study access window before we sequence the fitting work. I will ask the supplier about delivery flexibility while that dependency remains open.

Try it again: The decorator releases the study for Wednesday morning. Discuss what still needs checking with the supplier.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Reviewing fit, appearance, and snagging

At a wardrobe review you said all fronts were flush. The client points to drawer D3, whose left edge projects beyond the neighboring front. You have not assessed the cause or remedy. Correct your earlier statement and add the specific observation for follow-up.

My earlier statement that all the fronts were flush was too broad. At drawer D3, the left edge projects beyond the neighboring front. I will add that observation to the snag list and ask the joinery lead to review it. We have identified the appearance issue, but have not yet agreed its cause or remedy.

Try it again: The joinery lead cannot attend until Thursday. Agree the review appointment without promising a same-day remedy.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Handing over records and return visits

The owner receives cabinet drawings and the correct finish care sheet. A replacement shelf pin cover is due but not delivered. The joinery lead, Mina, accepts supplier follow-up and will call Friday. The return-visit date is not confirmed; warranty terms remain those in the supplied document.

Here are the cabinet drawings and the care sheet for the finish actually supplied. The shelf pin cover is still outstanding. Mina has accepted supplier follow-up and will call you Friday with its status; the return-visit date is not yet confirmed. Please keep the supplied warranty document for its specific terms rather than relying on a general verbal promise.

Try it again: The supplier changes the expected delivery. Explain the revised status without interpreting warranty coverage.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Carpenters

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/construction-and-extraction/carpenters.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Carpenters (47-2031.00), U.S. Department of Labor-sponsored occupational profile

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/47-2031.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

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Lesson 01: Confirming openings and measurement references

Original fictional case: The hall drawing labels a door opening 900 millimeters. The client assumes this is clear passage width. The note does not say rough or finished opening; no door has been ordered. The designer can clarify the reference.

Language workshop: Ask what the dimension describes

Communication goal: Distinguish a client's usable-space requirement from a drawing dimension.

Language guidance: An opening dimension needs units and reference surfaces. Rough opening, finished opening, door-leaf width, and usable clear passage are different quantities. Even a finished opening measurement may not establish passage with the door and hardware present. Ask which requirement matters before discussing an order size.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Is ___ measured between ___ or ___? / When you say clear width, do you mean ___? / We have the dimension, but still need ___.

Vocabulary: rough opening: The framed space intended to receive a door or window unit before surrounding finishes are complete. / finished opening: The opening measured between specified completed surrounding surfaces; this is not automatically the usable clear passage with a door installed and open. /

jamb: A side or top member of a door or window frame. / datum: An agreed reference point or line from which project dimensions are measured.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are the client. You need the usable passage clarified and have not chosen a door unit.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The designer confirms a rough opening, but the client still asks whether a large cabinet will fit. Separate the two measurements.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The drawing gives 900 millimeters, but it does not identify the measurement surfaces. Do you need that as the clear passage width, or were you referring to the framed opening? I will ask the designer to confirm the datum and jamb allowance before we treat this dimension as an order size.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT